

Persuasion Techniques

Technique	What it means	Typical effect on the reader	Example
Appeal to emotion	Using language or examples that trigger feelings such as fear, sympathy, anger or hope	Makes the reader feel emotionally involved and more likely to agree	"Imagine a child growing up without access to clean water."
Appeal to reason / logic	Using logical arguments and clear cause-and-effect relationships	Makes the argument appear rational and convincing	"If we reduce car use, we can lower emissions."
Appeal to authority	Referring to experts, scientists or respected institutions	Gives the argument credibility and makes it seem trustworthy	"According to leading climate scientists..."
Statistics / data	Using numbers, percentages or research findings	Creates an impression of objectivity and factual accuracy	"75% of students reported feeling stressed."
Examples / anecdotes	Providing specific cases or personal stories	Makes abstract arguments more concrete and relatable	"Take Sarah, a student who..."
Personal experience	Referring to the author's own experiences	Creates authenticity and can establish an emotional connection	"When I was a student, I experienced..."
Rhetorical questions	Questions that do not require an actual answer	Encourages readers to think about the issue and can guide them toward the author's conclusion	"How can we ignore this problem?"
Direct address	Speaking directly to the reader using <i>you</i>	Involves the reader personally and creates immediacy	"You have the power to make a difference."
Inclusive language	Using <i>we</i> , <i>us</i> , <i>our</i>	Creates a sense of community and shared responsibility	"We must work together to solve this problem."
Repetition	Repeating words, phrases or ideas	Emphasises key points and makes them memorable	"We need change. We need action. We need it now."
Anaphora	Repeating a word or phrase at the beginning of successive sentences/clauses	Creates emphasis, rhythm and emotional intensity	"We need courage. We need commitment. We need change."
Loaded / emotive language	Words with strong positive or negative associations	Influences the reader's emotional response to an issue	"This cruel and unnecessary policy..."
Hyperbole	Deliberate exaggeration	Makes an argument more striking or dramatic	"This decision will affect everyone on the planet."
Contrast / juxtaposition	Presenting opposing ideas or situations side by side	Highlights differences and makes the author's	"Some live in luxury while others struggle

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Metaphor	side Describing something in terms of something else	position clearer Makes complex ideas vivid and easier to understand	to survive.” “Social media is a double-edged sword.”
Analogy	Comparing one situation with another familiar one	Helps readers understand or accept an argument	“Managing a classroom is like conducting an orchestra.”
Cause and effect	Showing that one action or situation leads to another	Makes the argument appear logical and inevitable	“Excessive screen time can lead to poorer sleep.”
Counterargument + rebuttal	Mentioning an opposing view and then challenging it	Makes the author seem balanced and strengthens their own position	“Some argue that..., however...”
Concession	Acknowledging that an opposing argument has some validity	Makes the writer appear fair-minded and reasonable	“While this approach may be expensive, it is ultimately worthwhile.”
Call to action	Encouraging the reader to do something	Turns agreement into motivation or action	“It is time for us to take action.”
Imperatives	Using commands	Creates urgency and encourages the reader to act	“Consider the consequences. Take action.”
Word choice / diction	Deliberately selecting particular words to shape the reader's perception	Can make an issue appear positive, negative, urgent or harmless	“Freedom fighters” vs. “rebels”
Tone	The writer's attitude conveyed through language	Influences how the reader interprets the argument	A confident, sarcastic or concerned tone
Structure	Organising ideas strategically, e.g. building from problem to solution	Guides the reader through the argument and can make the conclusion more convincing	Problem → evidence → consequences → solution

What to write in an analysis

Avoid simply writing:

“The author uses statistics.”

Instead, explain the **purpose and effect**:

“The author uses statistics to provide factual evidence for her argument. By presenting numerical data, she makes her claims appear objective and credible, thereby encouraging the reader to accept her position.”

A useful formula is:

TECHNIQUE → EVIDENCE → PURPOSE → EFFECT

For example:

The author uses rhetorical questions (“How can we ignore this problem?”) to challenge the reader and draw attention to the seriousness of the issue. This encourages the audience to reflect on their own responsibility and makes the author's position appear difficult to reject.

Useful analytical verbs

Instead of repeatedly using “*the author uses...*”, you can write:

- **emphasises**
- **highlights**
- **illustrates**
- **reinforces**
- **underlines**
- **appeals to**
- **challenges**
- **encourages**
- **persuades**
- **convinces**
- **evokes**
- **creates**
- **establishes**
- **strengthens**
- **undermines**
- **contrasts**
- **draws attention to**
- **builds credibility**
- **creates a sense of urgency**
- **involves the reader**

A useful distinction

Technique ≠ effect.

For example:

Technique: inclusive pronouns (*we, us, our*)

Effect: creates a sense of unity and shared responsibility

Purpose: makes the reader more receptive to the author's proposed solution

